

Academic Paper

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The Louder Signifier

Encoding, anchorage, and how a performance about network propaganda re-enacted the asymmetry it set out to critique

MSJ2102: Convergence Communication I

University of Liberal Arts Bangladesh

Spring 2025

Case material: Fact Watch 'Trashion Show,' Bangladesh Shilpakala Academy — [video](#)

Abstract

This paper rereads two production exercises from Convergence Communication I — a static portrait poster and a live "Trashion" performance about network propaganda — as a single problem in the semiotics of communication: the gap between what a designer encodes and what an audience decodes. Drawing on Hall's encoding/decoding model, Barthes's account of anchorage, and the cognitive science of misinformation, it argues that the performance's most visible weakness, the illegibility of its fact-checker character, was not a craft failure but an unintended demonstration of the project's own thesis. The properties that let misinformation win in networked media — fluency, salience, speed — are the same properties that let the propagandist win on stage, while the epistemic virtues of fact-checking are precisely the ones that fail to read in a fast medium. The performance re-enacted the asymmetry it set out to critique. The paper closes on the practitioner's dilemma this exposes for counter-misinformation communication.

1. The problem behind both exercises

Convergence Communication I asked its students to make things: a portrait poster in Adobe Photoshop, and, in groups, a costumed live performance built from discarded material. Read as a production report, the two exercises have little in common beyond a shared semester. Read as communication, they pose the same question, and it is a serious one. When a designer arranges images, colours, and materials to say something, how much of that intended meaning actually reaches an audience that has no access to the designer's intentions? Every element I placed in the poster, and every material my group sewed onto a costume, was meant to carry a claim. The open question is whether those claims arrived.

This paper takes that question as its subject and argues a specific thesis about the group performance. The performance, a piece about how misinformation outcompetes fact-checking in networked media, failed in one identifiable way: its fact-checker character was illegible without spoken narration, while its propagandist read instantly. I will argue that this asymmetry, which our own audience and faculty flagged as the work's central weakness, is better understood as the work's central finding. The performance did not merely depict the thesis that truth is disadvantaged against spectacle. It reproduced that thesis in its own form, because the semiotic

and cognitive properties that make falsehood win in the feed are the same ones that make a loud, dense, fast character win on a stage. The poster serves as the controlled contrast that makes this argument legible: a static medium in which the same semiotic strategy does not fail. What follows is a reading of two objects, but the wider aim is a claim about the relationship between a message, its medium, and the audience that has to rebuild it.

2. Framework: meaning is reconstructed, not transmitted

The intuitive model of communication is a postal one: a sender packs a meaning into a message and a receiver unpacks it intact. Stuart Hall's encoding/decoding model dismantled that picture (Hall, 1980). A message is encoded by its producer within one set of codes and decoded by its audience within another, and the two need not match. Hall named three decoding positions: the dominant or preferred reading, in which the audience accepts the meaning the producer intended; the negotiated reading, in which it is partly accepted and partly resisted; and the oppositional reading, in which the audience understands the preferred meaning and rejects it. The consequence that matters here is simple. The encoder controls the signifier, the physical form of the message, but not the signified, the concept the audience attaches to it. Meaning is made twice, and the second making is not in the designer's hands.

Roland Barthes gives the mechanism a finer grain. Any image is polysemous: it carries a "floating chain of signifieds," and the viewer is free to select some and ignore others (Barthes, 1977). Cultures manage this dangerous freedom, Barthes argues, chiefly through language. The linguistic message performs anchorage, fixing the floating chain, steering the reader "through the signifieds of the image... remote-controlling him towards a meaning chosen in advance" (Barthes, 1977, p. 40). A caption, a title, a line of narration tells the viewer which of an image's many possible meanings is the intended one. Barthes distinguishes this from relay, where words and images stand in a complementary relation, as in comic-strip dialogue. Anchorage is the relevant concept for both my objects, because in each case language was recruited to pin down a visual argument that might otherwise drift.

Two refinements complete the frame. First, polysemy is not infinite, and decoding is work. Celeste Condit (1989), correcting an over-celebration of the "active audience," argued that texts constrain their readings, that audiences differ less in the meanings they construct than in their

evaluation of a largely shared meaning (she proposes polyvalence for this), and, crucially, that decoding against the grain of a text costs the viewer effort and time. Legibility, in other words, is a resource a text can spend generously or withhold. Second, to Peirce's typology of signs: an icon signifies by resemblance, an index by physical or causal connection, a symbol by convention (Chandler, 2007). The distinction will matter when we come to the costumes, because a design can lean on signs that a viewer grasps immediately and signs that require prior knowledge to read at all.

From these I want to name one variable that the two exercises together bring into view. Call it interpretive latency: the amount of decoding time and effort a medium permits its audience before the message is gone or overtaken. A printed poster grants high latency; a viewer may dwell, return, and reconstruct meaning at leisure. A live performance competing with other acts in a single evening grants very little. The same encoded message, requiring the same decoding labour, will succeed in the first medium and fail in the second. This is the hinge on which the whole argument turns.

3. The controlled case: a poster that tolerates latency

The individual exercise was to design a portrait poster of a classmate. My subject was Maimuna Nawar Rahman. The brief's genuine demand was not to photograph a person but to argue a person: to make a composition that said something specific rather than assembling a decorative collage. The material was her interests, her languages, her cat, an attachment to Japanese, Thai, and French culture.

The poster's semiotic strategy is worth setting out because it is, in retrospect, an exercise in managed polysemy. A black ground gives the elements visual gravity and forces them to read as discrete, deliberate objects rather than a continuous field; the eye moves between them and so treats each as a separate statement. Three national flags across the top encode the language interest iconically and immediately, before any text intervenes. A Tennyson line, "To strive, to seek, to find, and not to yield," set in a handwritten face against the geometric flags, encodes character rather than interest, and the deliberate typographic contrast marks the shift in register. A yellow ellipse and a yellow circle rhyme across the top and bottom of the frame, threading the

composition together without a drawn line. A small "art is life" badge, placed low and quiet, states the most personal claim in the least emphatic way, a decision not to oversell it.

Some of this reaches a stranger and some does not, and the honest account distinguishes them. The flags are close to fully legible: an iconic sign needs no caption. The Tennyson quotation is anchorage in Barthes's sense, language recruited to fix a meaning, but it anchors a signified available only to me. To a viewer who does not know what those lines mean in relation to Maimuna, the quotation fixes nothing; it floats. This is the gap between intended and received meaning appearing at small scale, and it is the same gap that will nearly sink the group project. What rescues the poster is not superior design. It is the medium. A poster grants high interpretive latency. The viewer can stand before it, read the quotation, look again, and assemble a negotiated reading over time. The design can afford a semi-private symbol because the format forgives slow decoding. Hold that fact; the performance had no such margin.

4. The live case: a performance about propaganda

The group project answered a semester theme, "Unmasking Network Propaganda," concerned with how misinformation spreads through digital networks, how algorithmic environments amplify whatever provokes emotion regardless of accuracy, and how repetition lends falsehoods a borrowed credibility. Our group, Fact Watch, made an interpretive choice that already contained the project's central tension: we built the piece around the fact-checker rather than the propagandist. The choice is honest and it is also a simplification, one we recognised at the time. The propagandist-versus-fact-checker frame offers a clear antagonist and a legible moral structure, but real fact-checking is slow, unglamorous, and structurally disadvantaged, and a corrective rarely travels as far as the falsehood it corrects. A theatrical frame imposes a clarity the phenomenon does not possess. We never fully resolved that tension, and, as I will argue, the unresolved version turned out to be more instructive than a resolved one.

The costumes, built from collected discard — scrap cloth, shells, wood, wire, cork, dead electronics — encoded the two roles through opposed material vocabularies. The propagandist was dense, industrial, and dynamic: a character of accumulation and noise, built to move and to dominate. The fact-checker was restrained and organic, ornamented with natural materials, seashells, peanut shells, leaves. That opposition was conceptually deliberate. Set against the

chaotic industrial density of the propagandist, the natural materials were meant to read as grounded and clarifying. The performance staged the confrontation directly: the propagandist enters with a placard reading "lies," performing the spread of misinformation through exaggerated, near-hysterical movement; the fact-checker enters, confronts him, takes the placard, and physically grounds him. Background narration supplied the interpretive frame.

Two production facts belong in the analysis rather than in an appendix, because each is evidence. First, the design drifted under the pressure of building. An illuminated halo intended to mark the fact-checker as a technological counter-force was abandoned when the electronics proved unreliable, and natural ornament took its place; the substitution quietly shifted the character's argument from "technological counter-force" to "natural purity," a different and weaker claim about what fact-checking is. A TV-box headdress that would have tied the propagandist explicitly to media cacophony was cut for want of time and materials. Both changes reduced the fact-checker's semiotic specificity and the propagandist's, but they reduced the fact-checker's more. Second, the medium's physical reality asserted itself in the crudest way: the performer in the male role got acrylic paint in his ear and was unwell for two days before it was removed at a hospital. It is recorded here for the same reason as the rest: a live medium imposes consequences a static one does not.

5. The reception data as a small decoding study

Because we interviewed five audience members afterwards, the project produced something a production report usually lacks: evidence about how the encoded message was actually decoded. The sample is tiny and self-selected and I make no representative claim for it, but as an illustrative decoding study it maps cleanly onto Hall's model. Two of the five reported the message as immediately clear, a preferred reading achieved at once. Three decoded it only with effort, on reflection or on a second viewing of the video, which is Condit's point exactly: the meaning was recoverable but the text made the audience pay for it in labour and time. One faculty respondent, Sheriff Al Sire, was specific and, I think, correct: the fact-checker's role was not evident from the visual storytelling, and the narration carried the interpretive load the costume and performance should have carried on their own.

That last observation is the finding restated in Barthes's vocabulary. The narration functioned as anchorage. It fixed a floating chain that the images alone left drifting, remote-controlling the audience toward the reading we intended. Anchorage is a legitimate tool; most communication uses it. But a design that depends on it has, by that dependence, conceded that the visual channel did not do its own work. The distribution of legibility is the key datum. Every respondent read the propagandist without help. The fact-checker required, variously, the narration, a second viewing, or an explicit suggestion (one respondent proposed adding a spoken or written frame precisely to close the gap). The asymmetry is not evenly spread across the piece. It sits on one character.

6. The reflexive turn: the form reproduced the thesis

Here is where a self-critique becomes an argument. The obvious reading of the reception data is that we under-designed the fact-checker and under-rehearsed the show, both true. But it stops short. The deeper reading asks why the failure fell where it did, on that character and not the other, and the answer implicates the project's own subject.

Consider what makes misinformation win in the environment the piece was about. Falsehood is more shareable and, empirically, spreads farther, faster, deeper, and more broadly than truth (Vosoughi, Roy, & Aral, 2018). It exploits processing fluency: claims that are easy to process feel more true, and mere repetition raises perceived accuracy, the illusory-truth effect, even among people who know better (Reber, Schwarz, & Winkielman, 2004; Fazio, Brashier, Payne, & Marsh, 2015). And once lodged, misinformation persists even after correction, the continued-influence effect, so that corrections both travel less and stick less (Lewandowsky, Ecker, Seifert, Schwarz, & Cook, 2012). The propagandist, in short, wins on salience, ease, speed, and repetition.

Now consider the stage. A live performance competing for attention in a crowded evening is an attention economy in miniature, and attention is the scarce resource for which the acts compete (Simon, 1971; Webster, 2014). In that economy the propagandist's semiotic register is optimal: dense, iconic, immediately legible, kinetic, loud. It is a high-fluency sign that resolves at a glance. The fact-checker's register is the opposite by design: restrained, quiet, dependent on natural materials whose meaning is indexical and conventional rather than instantly iconic, and

therefore requiring the viewer to work. The epistemic virtues we were trying to embody, patience, qualification, context, restraint, are disfluent virtues. They resist the glance. On a static poster, disfluency is survivable, because the medium grants latency. In a live, high-tempo, attention-scarce medium, disfluency is illegibility.

The semiotic detail is worth making explicit, because it shows the disadvantage was built into the material choices and not merely the execution. The propagandist's costume worked largely through iconic and heavily conventional signs: industrial density, wires and dead electronics, frantic motion, a vocabulary a contemporary audience reads almost reflexively as "media noise" and "chaos" because the resemblance is direct and the convention is saturated. The fact-checker's costume worked through indexical signs whose meaning has to be inferred. Seashells and leaves point to "nature," "grounding," "the organic," but the step from that natural register to the abstract idea of verification is one the viewer has to make unaided. An index asks the audience to reason from sign to referent; an icon hands over the referent on sight. In Peirce's terms (Chandler, 2007), we had encoded the antagonist iconically and the protagonist indexically, and indexical signs are close to being, by definition, slower to decode. The character carrying the argument we cared about was made from the higher-latency sign type and placed in the lower-latency medium. The mismatch was structural before a single rehearsal was missed.

So the costume asymmetry is not, at root, a craft error. It is the project's thesis appearing at the level of form. We set out to show that truth is structurally disadvantaged against spectacle in a fast medium, and we produced a fast-medium artefact in which truth's costume was structurally disadvantaged against spectacle's. The medium re-performed the message's own problem. The propagandist was legible for the same reason misinformation is legible; the fact-checker was hard to read for the same reason fact-checking is hard to hear. Read this way, the performance is not a flawed statement of its thesis. It is an unintended experiment that confirmed it, with the reception data as the result.

There is a further irony in the fix we reached for. Faced with an illegible visual argument, we anchored it with narration, an authoritative voice supplying the correct reading from outside the action. In performance terms this is close to a Brechtian move, a narrating frame that interrupts the spectacle to tell the audience how to understand it (Brecht, 1964). But it is worth naming what that concession means in the context of this particular subject. The counter-propaganda

message could only be secured by adding an external voice of authority to fix the meaning. That is, in compressed form, the whole predicament of fact-checking in networked media: the correction cannot win on the same terms as the falsehood, so it must arrive belatedly, from a position of asserted authority, telling people what they should already have seen.

7. The practitioner's dilemma

If the analysis is right, it produces a design problem rather than a lesson, and the problem does not have a comfortable solution. If the fact-checker was illegible because epistemic virtue is disfluent, then the intuitive remedy, make the fact-checker louder, denser, more dynamic, more spectacular, so that it can win the stage, carries a cost. To give truth the fluency of propaganda is to make truth behave like propaganda, and the behaviours in question, immediacy without qualification, salience without context, repetition, are precisely the ones that make misinformation epistemically dangerous. A fact-checker who wins the attention economy on its own terms may have stopped doing the thing that distinguished fact-checking in the first place. The alternative, preserving epistemic restraint, keeps the message honest and keeps it unheard.

This is not a tension peculiar to a student performance. It is the live problem of counter-misinformation communication in the platform era, where corrections must either be packaged for virality, and risk the flattening that virality demands, or remain accurate and under-circulated (Wardle & Derakhshan, 2017). What we could not see at the time is that this is not only a distribution problem to be solved downstream, by pushing corrections harder or wider, but an encoding problem upstream, in the form the correction takes. A correction built for fidelity to the evidence, hedged, conditional, precise, encodes disfluency into its own signifier, and then asks a fast medium to carry it. Our stage made that visible in the crudest possible way, but the same trade sits inside every fact-check that has to choose between being shareable and being exact. The performance, by failing in the specific way it failed, staged that dilemma more honestly than a polished version would have. A fact-checker costume that had "worked," that had beaten the propagandist for stage presence, would have resolved on stage a tension that is unresolved in the world, and would have been, in that sense, the less truthful artefact.

8. Coda: the audit question

The two exercises leave me with a working principle rather than a conclusion, and it takes the form of a question to run at the design stage: if I removed the explanation, what would remain? In the poster, a good deal remains, because the medium lets the viewer stay long enough to reconstruct it. In the performance, the propagandist remains and the fact-checker thins to a figure the narration has to rescue. The asymmetry in what survives the removal of language is the most exact available measure of where a design has done its own work and where it has been quietly outsourcing that work to a caption or a voice-over.

But the sharper lesson is the one the reflexive reading forces. Legibility is not a neutral craft goal to be maximised. Some messages are structurally disadvantaged in some media, and the disadvantage tracks the content: a message about the weakness of slow truth against fast spectacle will itself be weak, and slow, and easily out-shouted, in any fast and spectacular medium. Recognising that is not a counsel of despair. It is the beginning of designing around it, with clear eyes about the price of each available route. I offer the reading with the obvious caveats: a single small performance, an author who was also its portfolio-maker and eventual manager and so is implicated in the design being criticised, and a five-person feedback set that illustrates rather than proves. Within those limits, the claim stands. We built a piece about why truth loses to spectacle, and it lost, on cue, to its own.

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